

Authentic assessment via the Capstone Dossier.

Why MBA Rock students graduate with
a real business plan, not a transcript.

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Why MBA Rock students graduate with a real business plan — and what the research says about why that matters.

The case from the literature

Wiggins (1990) introduced the term *authentic assessment* in opposition to decontextualized standardized testing. Wiggins argued that assessment should require learners to perform the kind of tasks practitioners actually do in the domain — assembling a portfolio, executing a project, producing an artifact that has value outside the institutional context. The argument has been widely influential across higher education, professional training, and K-12 reform.

Newmann and Wehlage (1995) extended the case in their work on *authentic intellectual work*, arguing that schools producing tasks with meaning and utility beyond the institution — tasks that 'count' in real-world practice — produced measurably stronger learner outcomes than schools relying on decontextualized assessment.

Darling-Hammond and Snyder (2000) applied the authentic-assessment framework specifically to professional education, including teacher preparation. The core argument generalizes: in professional domains where the graduating learner must immediately function in practice, the assessment should look like the practice.

How the Capstone Dossier implements authentic assessment

The MBA Rock Capstone Dossier is a 10-section structured business plan that the learner builds across the curriculum, one section per module. The sections are: Strategy & Vision, Customer & Problem, Product or Service, Moat, Unit Economics, Operations, Capital, Marketing & Brand, Analytics & Learning, and Innovation & Next Plays.

Each section is grounded in the framework taught in the corresponding module, run against the learner's actual business or business idea (via the take-action prompts in each lesson and the calculators in the Operator's Console). The Dossier is therefore not a hypothetical academic exercise; it is the artifact the learner takes into practice.

The Dossier is exportable as a polished PDF — referred to externally as the Operator's Dossier. Co-branding allows institutional partners to issue the Dossier under joint identity with MBA Rock,

providing graduates with an artifact bearing the host institution's seal.

The compounding effect for lifelong success

Unlike a transcript or a static plan-as-PDF, the Capstone Dossier is designed to be returned to. As a graduate's business evolves — through scale events, capital rounds, market shifts — they update the relevant sections. Each return visit is a touch point with the institution's brand and a continued application of the frameworks. The authentic-assessment literature predicts this kind of artifact-anchored continued engagement produces stronger transfer and stronger long-term professional identity than transcript-anchored alternatives.

What this means for institutional partners. Programs that ship Capstone Dossiers — rather than only transcripts and diplomas — graduate their students with an artifact that has documented utility in professional practice. The authentic-assessment literature predicts stronger career outcomes, stronger framework transfer, and stronger continued engagement with the institution. For partner schools, this is a measurable lifelong-success differentiator few peer institutions can match without building equivalent artifact infrastructure.

References

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- Newmann, F. M., & Wehlage, G. G. (1995). *Successful school restructuring: A report to the public and educators*. Center on Organization and Restructuring of Schools, University of Wisconsin-Madison.
- Wiggins, G. (1990). The case for authentic assessment. *Practical Assessment, Research & Evaluation*, 2(2).